



HOW TO TELL WILD ANIMALS

English - Class 10 | Complete Comprehensive Study Notes

Author: Carolyn Wells

About the Author:

Carolyn Wells (1862-1942) was a prolific American author, poet, and novelist. She wrote more than 170 books, including mysteries, humour, poetry, and children's literature. She had a special talent for writing light-hearted, witty, and playful poems. Her style is full of fun, irony, and exaggeration, making serious or even scary topics entertaining. In this poem, she uses dark humour to describe dangerous wild animals in a way that teaches while making the reader laugh.

1. Themes and Values

Theme:

- Humorous and satirical way of identifying wild animals.
- The contrast between human cleverness and the raw power of nature.
- Danger hidden behind humour.
- Exaggeration and irony in describing the characteristics of wild beasts.
- Light-hearted take on fear and survival in the jungle.

Values:

- Learning through humour and fun is effective.
- Awareness and knowledge about wild animals can help in understanding nature.
- We should respect wild animals and their habitats.
- Never take dangerous situations lightly.
- Creativity and wit can make even fearful topics enjoyable.

2. Summary

How to Tell Wild Animals is a humorous poem that pretends to give practical advice on how to recognise different dangerous wild animals if one ever encounters them in the jungle. The poet uses a mocking, tongue-in-cheek tone. The "method" of identification is funny because by the time you correctly identify the animal, it has already attacked or killed you. This creates dark humour.

The poem has seven stanzas, each focusing on one or more animals. The language is simple, rhythmic, and full of rhyme, making it enjoyable to read aloud. The poet makes fear entertaining by presenting deadly animals in a comic way.

Instead of giving ordinary scientific descriptions, the poet gives exaggerated and ironic clues. The lion is known by its roar, the leopard by its attack, the tiger by its stripes, the bear by its crushing hug, the crocodile by its false tears, the hyena by its smile, and the python by its coiling grip.

The repeated joke is that the safest proof comes only after danger has already happened. This makes the poem funny, but it also reminds us that wild animals are powerful and must not be treated casually.

3. Stanza-wise Explanation

Stanza 1: The Asian Lion

If a traveller goes to the jungles in the east and sees a large tawny beast coming towards them, the loud roar of the animal will help identify it as the Asian Lion. The humour comes from the idea that the person realises this while dying of fear.

Stanza 2: The Leopard

If a person sees a noble wild beast with black markings on a yellow body and it leaps on them, the poet jokingly says that this is the way to identify the Leopard. The dangerous attack is presented as a "simple rule" for learning.

Stanza 3: The Bengal Tiger

The Bengal Tiger is identified by its black stripes on a yellow body. The poet again uses dark humour by suggesting that the attack itself becomes the proof of identification.

Stanza 4: The Bear

A bear is recognised through its powerful hug. The poet humorously describes the bear's deadly grip as if it were a friendly embrace, creating comedy through exaggeration and contrast.

Stanza 5: The Hyena and Crocodile

The crocodile is recognised by its false tears while eating, known as crocodile tears. The hyena is recognised by its smiling or laughing appearance. Both descriptions use irony and humour.

Stanza 6 & 7: The Python

The python is described as long, slimy, and scaly. It wraps itself around its victim and squeezes tightly. The poet turns this frightening image into a comic method of identification.

4. Overall Tone and Style

The entire poem is written in a mocking, playful manner. The poet repeatedly uses the idea that the final and surest proof of the animal's identity is when it attacks or kills you. This repeated joke runs throughout the poem and creates the main humour.

The poem seems to give useful advice, but actually highlights the foolishness of trying to identify wild animals only after they have attacked. Its tone is comic, witty, exaggerated, and satirical.

5. Literary Devices

- Rhyme Scheme: ABAB mostly, though it varies in places for comic rhythm.
- Alliteration: Repetition of consonant sounds, such as in phrases describing large beasts and black stripes.
- Irony: The whole poem is ironic because the identification happens too late.
- Humour: Dark humour and sarcasm make dangerous situations funny.
- Imagery: Clear visual images - tawny lion, spotted leopard, striped tiger, hugging bear, weeping crocodile, smiling hyena, and coiling python.
- Repetition: Repeated identification pattern creates comic effect.
- Satire: Gentle satire on human overconfidence in the face of nature's power.
- Exaggeration: The descriptions are deliberately overdone to make the poem funny and memorable.

6. Moral (in points)

- Wild animals are dangerous and should not be approached casually.
- Humour can make learning about scary things easier and more memorable.
- We must respect the power and territory of wild animals.
- Knowledge of animal behaviour is important for safety in forests.
- Never underestimate nature - animals act according to their instincts.

- Creative and funny writing can teach important lessons effectively.
- It is always better to observe animals from a safe distance.
- Preservation of wildlife and their natural habitats is necessary so that such dangerous encounters remain rare.

This poem beautifully balances education with entertainment, teaching children about animals while making them smile.

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